Takeout Double

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The takeout double is a double that asks partner to bid one of the unbid suits. The double usually shows 11+ points and 3+ cards in each unbid suit. Some basic examples:

South
♠A532
♥KQJ5
♦AT93
♣7

West	North	East	South
Pass	Pass	1♣	Dbl [1]

(1) Takeout double, asking partner to bid diamonds, hearts or spades — whichever suit he has the greatest length and strength in.

♠AQ32
♥K4
♦AT973
♣72

West	North	East	South
1♣	Pass	1♥	Dbl [1]

(1) Takeout double, asking partner to bid diamonds or spades.

♠A532
♥KJT5
♦6
♣KQT3

West	North	East	South
1♦	Pass	1NT	Dbl [1]

(1) Not for penalty; asks partner to bid clubs, hearts or spades.

Takeout doubles can also be made with strong one-suited hands (16+ points):

♠AKQ32
♥A4
♦KQ3
♣752

West	North	East	South
1♣	Pass	Pass	Dbl [1]
Pass	1♥	Pass	1♠ [2]

(1) Takeout double.
(2) A new suit by the doubler shows a strong one-suited hand. However, this is not forcing.

Responses to a Takeout Double

After hearing a takeout double from partner, the following actions are available.

Response	Meaning
Pass	Converts the takeout double into a penalty double. At the one- and two-levels of bidding, Pass shows a very strong trump holding, general values, and no biddable suit. A low-level Pass should never be made on a weak hand that wants to be excused from bidding. It especially should not be made on a weak hand with a handful of little trumps. At higher auction levels, the Pass can be based more on points and/or flat shape.
A "cheapest-level" suit response	Natural, 3+ cards (usually 4+ cards) and 0-9 points. Not forcing.
A jump shift in a suit	Natural, 4+ cards and 10-12 points. Not forcing.
A double jump shift in a suit	In response to a double at the 1-level, this is weak, 6+ card suit and 6-8 points. Not forcing. Note that some partnerships may play this as strong.
A "cheapest-level" no-trump bid	Natural, balanced, 7-10 HCP. Promises a stopper in the enemy suit. Tends to deny a biddable 4-card major.
A jump shift in no-trumps	Natural, balanced, 11-12 HCP. Otherwise, see above.
3NT	Balanced with a stopper in the opponents' suit(s), signoff. Opposite a 1-level takeout double, this shows roughly 13-15 HCP.
Cue-bid	10+ points, artificial and forcing. Typically unbalanced without a better alternative bid. Some may play this stronger, showing a game-forcing 12+ points. Doubler's rebids are natural.

Ranges vary slightly by partnership, but this is in the ballpark of common practice.

Responses After Interference

If your right-hand opponent bids over partner's double, then any "free" bid shows 6+ points and at least a 4-card suit. If the takeout double is redoubled, all bids are natural but jump suit bids become preemptive, showing at least 5 cards and 0-8 points.

How high to play takeout doubles is a matter of partnership agreement. Many partnerships play takeout doubles through the 3-level, and then "optional" or penalty doubles beyond that.

Rebids by the Doubler

If partner hasn't promised any strength, the doubler should only bid again with a very good hand.

The following are the rebids after partner has responded 1 of a suit (possibly with 0 points).

Response	Meaning

1NT	If your immediate 1NT overcall shows a balanced 15-18 HCP with a stopper, then this shows a bad 18 to 20 HCP. Not forcing.
2NT	21-22 HCP, balanced, promising a stopper. Not forcing.
A new suit	Natural, 5+ cards, 19+ points. Not forcing.
Single raise of partner's suit	16-18 points, 4+ card support. Not forcing.
Jump raise of partner's suit	19-21 points, 4+ card support. Not forcing.
Cue-bid	19+ points, one-round force. No other suitable bid.

Any other bid (such as raising to game, leaping to 3NT, raising 1NT to 2NT etc.), is strong. If you play splinter bids, you can treat a jump cue-bid in the enemy suit as a splinter in support of partner's suit.

See also

- Equal Level Conversion
  A method of showing certain 4-5 hands after a takeout double.
- Lightner Double
  A lead-directing double of an enemy slam contract.
- Low-Level Penalty Double
  A double of an enemy partscore that isn't artificial, e.g. takeout.
- Maximal Double
  A conventional double used as a major suit game try.
- Negative Double
  A conventional double used by responder after opener starts the bidding with one-of-a-suit and the next player makes a suit overcall.
- Optional Double
  A conventional double made after an opponent has opened the bidding with a preempt.
- Responsive Double
  A conventional double used when partner makes a takeout double and the next player raises his partner's suit.
- Snapdragon Double
  A conventional double by fourth seat after the first three players bid three different suits.
- SOS Redouble
  A conventional redouble that asks partner to bid a new suit.
- Stripe-Tailed Ape Double
  A double of an enemy game contract, in hopes of stopping the opponents from continuing on to slam.
- Support Double
  A conventional double used by opener after partner makes a suit response and the next player overcalls.
- Thrump Double
  A double of a 3-level preempt asking partner to bid 3NT with a stopper.